

India travelled to Australia in 2024 without him and suffered a humiliating series defeat.

"I personally feel that the Indian team needed me in Australia, and I was fully ready for it..." he had said, indicating that age shouldn't be the defining factor in selection.

"Age is just a number. If a player has the experience and if he is still playing domestic cricket and giving his best, the selectors should consider him. It's not about the age. It's about the intent. It's about the passion for red-ball cricket and the hard work that you put in the middle..."

Perhaps that was the quiet tragedy of Rahane's final years in domestic cricket. He wasn't trying to remind people of what he had achieved. He was trying to prove he still belonged.

That's why he continued playing for Mumbai until last season.

He struggled, but scored when the team needed him and remained relevant. When he scored another Ranji Trophy hundred against Chhattisgarh, the celebration lasted barely a few seconds. A raised bat. A thumbs-up towards the dressing room. Then he took guard again.

Asked why his celebration was so muted after another Ranji hundred, Rahane said: "Something clicked for me. I know how good a player I am, so I don't like to focus on what's going on outside. There are many unwanted people who don't know about the game, but they still talk about a player who has been playing consistently with good attitude and good intensity..."

That was Rahane. He rarely looked for validation.

"Whenever a series is on, I am not on social media... I make it a point to cut out the noise and don't even read whatever is being written about me — be it positive or negative," he revealed.

Public relations mattered little to him.

"When you are scoring runs and doing well, the whole world will appreciate your efforts... but when you are not doing well, you have to see how many people are actually supporting you,"* he had said, before adding with a smile: "My kids tell me, 'Daddy, you can do it...' and when they support you, nothing else matters..."

After those remarks, Rahane had a long discussion with national selector Pragyan Ojha in

Jaipur last year. It seemed to give him the clarity that another comeback was unlikely. He skipped the remainder of the Ranji Trophy, played only the Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy and shifted his focus to preparing for the IPL with Kolkata Knight Riders.

The month that defined him

For all his successes and failures, it was December 2020 that came to define Ajinkya Rahane. India had just been bowled out for 36 in

Adelaide. Virat Kohli had flown home.

Mohammed Shami



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